

USCIS

Attn: Premium I-140

P.O. Box 4008

Carol Stream, IL 60197-4008

Petition Cover Letter

Petitioner/Beneficiary: Ms. Martha Kakooza

Classification Petition: Extraordinary Ability in Education (EB-1A). Sec. 203(b)(1) INA [8 U.S.C. 1153].

Martha Kakooza
29 Linden Terrace,
Towson, MD, 21286
443-519-6759
marthankakooza@gmail.com

March 2nd 2026

USCIS
Attn: Premium I-140
P.O. Box 4008
Carol Stream, IL 60197-4008

**RE: EB-1A Immigration Petition for Alien Worker - Preference Allocation for
Employment-Based Immigrants**

Petitioner/Beneficiary: Ms. Martha Kakooza
Nature of submission: INITIAL EVIDENCE
Type of Petition: I-140, EB-1A Extraordinary Ability in Education
Classification Sought: Employment-Based Immigration, First Preference, Extraordinary Ability
in Education (EB-1A). Sec. 203(b)(1) INA [8 U.S.C. 1153]

Dear USCIS Officer

I am writing to respectfully submit this letter in support of my petition for classification as a qualified immigrant under the **first preference employment immigration** for Aliens of Extraordinary Ability pursuant to section 203(b)(1)(A) of the Immigration and Nationality Act (“the Act”), 8 U.S.C. § 1153(b)(1)(A). The evidence provided here demonstrates that:

- (i) I have met **four of the regulatory criteria** set at 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3), and
- (ii) (a) I have achieved a level of expertise indicating that I am “one of that small percentage who have risen to the very top of the field of endeavor” as defined by 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(2); and
(b) I have sustained national or international acclaim and recognition for my achievements in my area of expertise, as required by 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3).

The evidence submitted demonstrates that I have fulfilled the two-part criteria outlined in the Kazarian case, *Kazarian v. USCIS*, 596 F.3d 1115 (9th Cir. 2010). This approach involves the initial counting of evidence to determine if at least three criteria are met, followed by a final merits determination.

Pursuant to section 203(b)(1)(A) of the Act, upon establishing that I have extraordinary ability in my field of endeavor, the evidence submitted proves that I qualify for classification as an alien of extraordinary ability, as I seek to enter the United States to continue work in my area of

expertise, and my entry to the United States will substantially benefit the national economy and educational interests of the United States.

Thank you for considering my petition.

Sincerely,
Martha Kakooza.

Table of contents

1. Advanced Degree Professional
2. Substantial Merit and National Importance
3. Evidence of Extraordinary Ability
 - a. **Criterion 1**-Evidence of my receipt of lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence in my field of endeavor.
 - b. **Criterion 4**- Evidence that I have been asked to judge the work of others, either individually or on a panel
 - c. **Criterion 6** - Evidence of my authorship of scholarly articles.
 - d. **Criterion 7** - Evidence of display of work in an exhibition
4. Kazarian Final Merits Determination.
5. Conclusion
6. Signed statement from Ms. Kakooza detailing plans on how she intends to continue working in the United States

The content of this petition letter is divided into chapters to clearly address all required criteria.

1 Advanced Degree Professional

Evidence of Advanced Degree

I am currently completing a Ph.D. in Higher Education Administration and Student Affairs at Morgan State University (**Exhibit 1 Academic Transcript from Morgan State University**) a Carnegie-classified Doctoral Research University with high research activity (R2) and Maryland's designated Preeminent Public Urban Research University. The School of Education and Urban Studies at Morgan State University, where I am completing my doctoral education. My doctoral training builds upon Master of Science in Women and Gender Studies from Towson University, Baltimore, Maryland (**Exhibit 2 Master's Degree Certificate**). The frameworks developed during my master's studies directly inform my doctoral research design, interpretive approach, and analytical focus, particularly in examining how institutional practices shape graduate student experiences across STEM and higher education contexts.

Based on the facts demonstrated above, I am a member of the professions holding an advanced degree.

2. Substantial Merit and National Importance

My work is situated within the field of higher education research, with specialized expertise in STEM graduate education and doctoral student development. My research examines how institutional structures, including mentoring systems, program design, evaluation practices, and academic climate, shape research training, academic engagement, and workforce outcomes. This field is of substantial merit and national importance because STEM graduate and doctoral education are foundational to the United States' scientific workforce, research enterprise, and innovation capacity.

Federal agencies identify STEM workforce development and doctoral training as national priorities essential to economic competitiveness, technological innovation, and U.S. leadership in science and technology. **July 2025, the National Science Foundation states that**

“a strong workforce is vital to maintaining the nation’s standard of excellence and global leadership in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM)” and that its investments “strengthen our domestic workforce to fuel economic prosperity, national security, and global science and engineering competitiveness,”

reflecting a focus on excellence, merit, and broadening participation in STEM fields (**Exhibit 3 Improving America's workforce: Promoting American prosperity through STEM education**).

Similarly, National Science Foundation’s strategic objectives reaffirm that the U.S. must

“support the growth of positions in critical and emerging technologies by developing the next generation science, technology, engineering and mathematics workforce,”

demonstrating the federal commitment to building human capital through research and training programs (**Exhibit 4 National Science Foundation Creating a STEM Workforce**).

Furthermore, **on January 16, 2026, the U.S. The Department of Energy (DOE)** released a request for information issue that has articulated a national objective to build a skilled science and engineering workforce spanning undergraduate through **doctoral and post-doctoral levels as part of its transformative research agenda (Exhibit 5 Mobilizing Talent for the Genesis Mission and Developing an American Workforce to Advance Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Science and Engineering)**. In its Request for Information on advancing AI for science and engineering workforce development, DOE states that meeting the goals of the Genesis Mission will require;

“a workforce of 100,000 American scientists and engineers ... trained over the next decade to lead the world in AI-powered science, innovation, and applications,”

and highlights the need to establish training pipelines that span bachelor's, master's, doctoral, and post-doctoral stages in partnership with institutions of higher learning, think tanks and philanthropic organizations. *(Exhibit 5 Mobilizing Talent for the Genesis Mission and Developing an American Workforce to Advance Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Science and Engineering)*

The Department of Energy explicitly states that they are seeking input on how to structure training programs, expand research opportunities for students, and foster partnerships across sectors highlighting that this training is of importance to the United States

(Exhibit 5 Mobilizing Talent for the Genesis Mission and Developing an American Workforce to Advance Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Science and Engineering).

Within this context, my educational work and research focuses on how higher education and the influence of STEM doctoral student engagement, persistence, and research development, and egalitarianism in higher education research factors federal agencies increasingly recognize as central to the development of the American workforce preparation, and responsible stewardship of public investment

2. 1 National Importance of STEM Graduate Education and Doctoral Student Development

As the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) request for information stated

“Educational institutions partners would form highly collaborative research teams to meet the aggressive goals of the Genesis Mission. They would also establish research experiences as part of doctoral and post-doctoral associate training.” (Exhibit 5 Mobilizing Talent for the Genesis Mission and Developing an American Workforce to Advance Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Science and Engineering).

My educational research contributes directly to these priorities by examining higher education, specifically STEM graduate experiences, doctoral students' research experiences and equity in higher education research. Using rigorous educational research methodologies, I generate empirically grounded insights that inform doctoral program improvement, mentoring practices, and institutional effectiveness. This work aligns with federal goals to enhance graduate education quality and prepare a STEM workforce capable of advancing scientific discovery and technological innovation.

2.2 Science, Technology Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) Educational Research, Institutional Capacity, and Broader National Impact

STEM Educational research has emerged as a national priority because disparities in doctoral training and graduate education limit the full development of the U.S. research workforce. Federal initiatives such as NSF INCLUDES and NSF ADVANCE emphasize strengthening **institutional capacity** to support broad participation in research training and to improve the effectiveness of graduate education systems nationwide. NSF INCLUDES articulates a comprehensive national vision to

“catalyze the STEM enterprise to work collaboratively for change, resulting in a STEM workforce that reflects the Nation’s population,”

and emphasizes that broadening participation will yield

“a new generation of STEM talent and leadership to secure the Nation’s future and long-term economic competitiveness.”

Likewise, the NSF ADVANCE program

“contributes to the National Science Foundation’s goal of a more diverse and capable science and engineering workforce” (Exhibit 6 NSF's Eddie Bernice Johnson Inclusion across the Nation of Communities of Learners of Underrepresented Discoverers in Engineering and Science Initiative)

by supporting systemic change strategies that promote STEM faculty and research environments My work addresses these priorities by analyzing how **institutional policies and evaluative practices** shape access to mentorship, research integration, and professional development in doctoral education. **My work in education and research provides institution-level evidence that supports data-informed decision-making, programmatic reform, and accountability in graduate education.** By informing how institutions design, evaluate, and improve doctoral training environments, my work supports national objectives related to research excellence.

2.3 Summary of National Importance

In sum, **my extraordinary ability in education sits at the intersection of higher educational research, STEM graduate education, doctoral educational pathways and egalitarianism in higher education research, addressing federally articulated priorities central to the nation’s research and innovation infrastructure.** By strengthening doctoral education systems, advancing evidence-based approaches to STEM graduate training, and informing institutional responsibility for doctoral student development, my contributions generate national-level benefits that extend beyond any single institution or employer. **These efforts align directly with federal priorities to strengthen the U.S. research workforce, enhance doctoral training quality, and support sustained innovation across science, technology, health, and energy sectors, objectives widely recognized as matters of substantial merit and national importance.**

3. Evidence of Extraordinary Ability

I possess **extraordinary ability** in **higher education research**, specifically STEM graduate education, equity research, doctoral student development and pathways contributing to a field of recognized national importance.

3.1 Criterion 1 - Receipt of nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence

As required by 8 CFR § 204.5(h)(3)(i), I provide evidence of "receipt of lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence in the field of endeavor."

I have received prestigious awards and recognitions that demonstrate my extraordinary ability in higher education research, specifically STEM graduate education, doctoral student development and equity in higher education research. These awards come from different national and internationally recognized organizations in the field of higher education and education research and development including leading educational organizations and professional organizations validating the widespread recognition of my exceptional talents. Each award listed below resulted from highly competitive selection processes and represents nationally and internationally recognized marks of distinction of excellence in the educational community.

Award 1: Donald H. Wulff Fellowship with the POD Network in Higher Education.

Evidence of receipt of the award

In 2025, I was selected as a **Donald H. Wulff Diversity Fellow** by the **Professional and Organizational Development (POD) Network in Higher Education**, a nationally prominent professional association with **national and international reach**. My selection was the result of a **rigorous, peer-reviewed national competition and egalitarianism in higher education research**. For the most recent fellowship cycle, POD received **48 applications for only 9 fellowship positions**, resulting in an **acceptance rate of 18.75%**

(Exhibits A-1: Donald Wulff Fellow Appointment Letter (POD Network in Higher Education, A-2: POD Letter to the Dean at Morgan State University confirming fellowship selection, A-3: Association of Study of Higher Education(ASHE) Newsletter Announcement recognizing the Petitioner).

This quantitative selectivity demonstrates that the fellowship is awarded to a **small minority of applicants**, underscoring the program's exclusivity and prestige. The Award is also open to graduate students, senior educational developers, professors from universities among others. Fellows are recognized during the Awards Ceremony at the POD Network Annual Conference, which was held in San Diego, California November 20-23, 2025. As documented in my official selection materials, I was awarded **formal fellowship status** along with **financial support** to participate in POD's national

programming, including **conference registration and associated professional development activities.**

Evidence that the award is based on excellence in the field of higher education

My official selection letter explicitly states:

“Ms. Kakooza’s selection for this fellowship represents recognition of demonstrated commitment and excellence to educational development, and potential to contribute meaningfully to advancing academic innovation in higher education.”

(Exhibit A-2: POD Letter to the Dean at Morgan State University confirming fellowship selection,).

My selection specifically recognized my excellence in academic innovation and educational development, **particularly my work addressing critical and emerging challenges in STEM graduate education and egalitarianism in higher education research.** This was further evidenced by my invitation to present during the Wulff Fellows national roundtable discussion, where I shared my work on STEM graduate education and doctoral pathways with leading educators, researchers, principal investigators, and academic leaders.

(Exhibit A-4 POD Wulff Fellows Roundtable Presentation)

Evidence that the award is nationally recognized

The Donald Wulff Fellowship is nationally recognized in the field of higher education educational development because it **is awarded by the POD Network**, a leading national professional organization in educational development. **The POD Network is North America’s largest educational development community, represented in every US state and more than 30 countries.**

The POD Network founded in 1976 is North America’s largest educational development community, with approximately 1,800 members representing every U.S. state and more than 30 countries. The Network includes faculty, academic leaders, deans, instructional developers, and graduate scholars engaged in higher education research and practice

(Exhibit A-5: POD Network Annual Conference documentation).

Through its nearly 50-year history and annual national conference, a major convening for professional development and research dissemination in educational development

(Exhibit A-6: Overview of POD Network membership and organizational profile)

The POD Network serves as a nationally recognized platform for advancing scholarship, networking, and innovation in higher education.

This honor meets the EB1A criterion for “*receipt of lesser nationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence*,” as it is awarded based on a documented record of educational innovation and significant research impact by a founding and nationally recognized education organization.

This recognition aligns directly with the regulatory criteria for EB 1A classification under 8 CFR Section 204.5(h)(3)(i), which recognizes "receipt of lesser nationally or internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence in the field of endeavor" as evidence of extraordinary ability. The **Donald H. Wulff Fellow** selection represents precisely such a recognition of excellence from a globally renowned industry leader.

Award 2 American Association of Colleges and Universities (AAC&U) Future Leaders Society Award

Evidence of receipt of the award

As evidence of selection-based recognition, I was selected as an awardee in 2023. The American Association of Colleges and Universities. **Receipt of the award is demonstrated by induction into the AAC&U Future Leaders Society, an internationally established higher education association, of leadership and professional impact**

(Exhibit A-7: AAC&U Letter to the Dean, School of Education, Morgan State University)

The official AAC&U verification letter further documents that I was recognized for my demonstrated excellence in higher education.

Evidence that the award is based on excellence in the field of higher education

As stated in the letter by Kathryn A. E. Enke, Ph.D., Vice President for Leadership and Strategy, American Association of Colleges and Universities (Exhibit A-7: AAC&U Letter to the Dean, School of Education, Morgan State University)

The AAC&U Future Leaders Society were nominated by faculty and staff across international higher education and identified through a competitive selection process and for their excellence demonstrated in higher education. Participants were inducted into a year-long community providing on-demand professional development resources and regular virtual peer networking events. The Future Leaders Society was generously supported by the L. Lee Knefelkamp Fund and advised by past AAC&U Award winners who are experts on postsecondary teaching and learning.

This honor reflects **selection based on achievement and demonstrated excellence in higher education research**. AAC&U confirms that candidates were **nominated by**

faculty and staff across international higher education and identified through a competitive selection process i.e., participation required third-party nomination and selection

(Exhibit A-7: AAC&U Letter to the Dean, School of Education, Morgan State University)

The letter also confirms the Society functioned as a **year-long community** that provided “on-demand professional development resources” and “regular virtual peer networking events,” indicating a structured cohort experience and further investment into the awardees.

Evidence that the award is internationally recognized

The American Association of Colleges and Universities (AAC&U) is a nonprofit, global membership organization focused on strengthening undergraduate education, especially the goals and practices commonly associated with education. This is the awarding body of the Future Leaders Society award (Exhibit A-8: AAC&U Mission Statement)

AAC&U member bolsters over 1,000 university members worldwide and the award was open to all participating member universities for nomination such as:

- American University, Blagoevgrad, Bulgaria
- Brown University, Providence, United States
- H. Lavity Stoutt Community College, Tortola, Virgin Islands British
- Harvard University, Massachusetts, United States
- Hebrew Union College-Jewish Institute of Religion, Jerusalem, Israel (*Exhibit A-10: AAC&U Member Institutions List demonstrating national and international reach*)

This means that the Future Leaders Society award was open to all members of the participating universities. The competitive selection process drew applicants from top academic programs nationwide and internationally, further emphasizing the significance of being chosen as an award recipient. These distinctions represent recognition on an international scale by respected professional societies with a proven record of advancing doctoral excellence.

The award thus fully satisfies the EB1A regulatory criterion for “receipt of internationally recognized prizes or awards for excellence in the field of endeavor,” as specified under 8 CFR § 204.5(h)(3)(i) and supporting USCIS guidance on internationally recognized awards.

Award 3: Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN) — Research Accelerator Award Winner (2021)

Evidence of receipt of the award

In 2021, I was selected as a **Research Accelerator Award** winner through the Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN), a competitively conferred, externally supported national research award (Exhibit A-11: IGEN Research Accelerator Award Letter).

My selected project, *Cross-Stitching Our Stories: Unweaving the Threads of Narrative Self-Construction in Black Women and Femmes' Personal Statements*, was chosen through **comparative evaluation of proposals submitted by researchers from multiple institutions and I was awarded \$2599 in order to conduct additional higher education research**(Exhibit A-11: IGEN Research Accelerator Award Letter).

Evidence that the award is based on excellence in the field of higher education

The Research Accelerator Award administered by the Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN) was conferred through a competitive, merit-based proposal review **process open to graduate students, faculty, postdoctoral scholars, professional scientists, and disciplinary society staff based on excellence of research on STEM graduate education in the United States.**

(Exhibit A-12: IGEN Call for Proposals outlining competitive application process, Exhibit A-13: Letter of Notification from Inclusive Graduate Education Network)

Proposals were comparatively evaluated based on scholarly merit, relevance to advancing theory and evidence on barriers to full participation in STEM graduate education. The award provided competitively allocated, externally supported seed funding, reflecting national recognition of the project's scholarly excellence and its contribution to advancing STEM graduate education.

Evidence that the award is nationally recognized

IGEN operates as a **National Science Foundation (NSF) INCLUDES Alliance, a federally designated national initiative established to catalyze system-level reform in U.S. STEM graduate education.** The awarding body IGEN convenes disciplinary societies, universities, doctoral programs, and research centers nationwide.

(Exhibits A-15: IGEN Frequently Asked Questions, A-16: "What Is IGEN?" program overview, A-17: IGEN 2019–2025 Final Outcomes Report)

The evidentiary strength of this award is further reinforced by **its funding sources and institutional anchoring that is the National Science Foundation and the University of Southern California.**

Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN) is a partnership of over 30 academic societies, institutions, organizations, corporations, and national laboratories poised to lead a paradigm shift in broadening participation for students who enter graduate or doctorate level programs in the physical sciences housed at the University of Southern California.

Furthermore, other winners who received this award come from all over the nation and work in globally acclaimed and recognized research institutions. The Top 5 in 2021 year's list (except myself) include:

1. Dr. Radomir Ray Mitic, University of North Dakota;
2. Dr. Natalie Lundsteen and Dr. Arnaldo Diaz Vazquez, University of Texas Southwestern;
3. Dr. Andrea L. Tyler, Tennessee State University;
4. Dr. Annie M. Wolford, Northern Arizona University;
5. Dr. Ankur Desai, Zoë Brooke Zibton and Alicia Hoffman, University of Wisconsin-Madison (Exhibit A-14: "2021 Research Accelerator Awardees Named" public announcement)

As the only doctoral student recipient of the 2021 Research Accelerator Award my receipt of the award distinguishes me among my contemporaries in the field of STEM graduate education and higher education and demonstrates national recognition of my extraordinary ability.

The competitive peer review, limited number of awardees, national applicant pool, and association with federally funded and nationally recognized organizations establish that the IGEN Research Accelerator Award constitutes a lesser nationally recognized prize or award for excellence under 8 CFR § 204.5(h)(3)(i). The award reflects recognition of excellence in STEM graduate education research.

3.2 Criterion 4. Evidence as a judge of the work of others in the same or an allied field of specialization.

As required by **8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(iv)**, I submit evidence of my **participation as a judge of the work of others** in the field of higher education, graduate education and STEM education research. This criterion evaluates whether a petitioner has been **entrusted with formal evaluative authority** to assess the scholarly or professional work of peers in the same or an allied field.

As documented in the exhibits below, I have been **invited, selected, and relied upon** to evaluate the scholarly work of other researchers through **peer review for academic journals and national research conferences**. In each instance, I received an invitation and **completed substantive reviews** that directly informed editorial or program decisions regarding acceptance, revision, or rejection. These roles reflect sustained professional trust in my expertise and constitute direct evidence of qualifying activity under this criterion.

Judging 1: Review Board Member for the Journal of Women and Gender in Higher Education

Evidence that I was invited to be a judge

Through a peer review process, I was invited to be a part of the review board for the Journal of Women and Gender in Higher Education(Exhibit B-1: Email notification from Journal of Women and Gender in Higher Education (JWG) Editor confirming reviewer appointment, Exhibit B-2: Journal of Women and Gender in Higher Education – Reviewer Guidelines) .

*Dear Martha,
Congratulations! I'm thrilled to send this message to let you know that you've been accepted as a member of the JWG Review Board, class of 2025! Your term begins in January 2022 and will continue through March 2025, with the option to renew if you desire to do so.*

Evidence that it is related to the field of higher education

The Journal of Women and Gender in Higher education reports approximately 29,000 annual downloads/views, reflecting sustained readership and visibility within higher education scholarship and practice and egalitarianism in higher education research. Its citation indicators further demonstrate that it is an established, internationally indexed outlet within its niche.

(ExhibitB-3: Journal of Women and Gender in Higher Education – Aims and Scope)

Evidence that I have completed the judging

In this capacity, I have been entrusted with evaluating the scholarly work of other **researchers and exercising independent expert judgment on whether manuscripts** should be published in the academic journal or not. **I have done 7 reviews of different manuscripts**

(Exhibit B-4: Invitations to review and completed review records (JWG), Exhibit B-5: Screenshot from journal website showing completed reviews)

Judging 2: Invited Manuscript Reviewer — *International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education (IJQSE)*

Evidence that I was invited to be a judge

I was **invited to be a manuscript reviewer** for the *International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education (IJQSE)*, a peer-reviewed journal published by Taylor & Francis. **The invitation was after publication of a co-authored peer reviewed article** with IJQSE. As noted in an email from the Managing Editor Josh Manlove

(Exhibit B-6: International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education (IJQSE) reviewer invitation email (Manuscript ID TQSE-2024-0022))

Thank you for being a part of our duoethnography project and also for supporting the peer review process for the special issue. Below is the formal invitation from

the journal as well as information to access the manuscript and submit your review.

Evidence that it is related to the field of higher education

International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education (IJQSE), started in 1988 an internationally recognized, peer-reviewed journal published by Taylor & Francis that plays a significant role in shaping qualitative and interpretive scholarship in education and higher education.(Exhibit B-7: IJQSE Journal Aims and Scope).

Evidence that I have completed the judging

In this capacity, I have completed **review of empirical research papers** and provide formal written evaluations assessing research design, analytic rigor, theoretical contribution, and relevance to the field.

(Exhibit B-8: IJQSE reviewer invitation emails and review confirmation records)

Judging 3 Manuscript Peer Reviewer- ADVANCE Journal (National Science Foundation-Aligned)

Evidence that I was invited to be a judge

In 2025, I was entrusted with formal evaluative authority as **an invited manuscript peer reviewer** for the *ADVANCE Journal*, a peer-reviewed, open-access academic journal focused on institutional transformation in higher education, particularly within Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics contexts

(Exhibit B-9: Email invitation from ADVANCE Journal editor)

Dear Martha,

The ADVANCE Journal would like to invite you to review a manuscript that was recently submitted to us. Based on your expertise, I thought you would be the perfect reviewer for this piece.

Evidence that it is related to the field of higher education

The journal publishes **scholarship aligned with the National Science Foundation ADVANCE initiatives**, started as part of the National Science Foundation's ADVANCE Institutional Transformation and **related federal efforts to improve equity, faculty development, and organizational change in postsecondary education.**

(Exhibit B-10: ADVANCE Journal website – Scope and Focus).

Evidence that I have completed the judging

(Exhibit B-11: ADVANCE Journal completed review submission confirmation)

Your review for “Conceptual Conflation and Terminological Troubles: Understandings of Gender in STEM Disciplinary Based Education Research” has been **successfully submitted** to *ADVANCE Journal*. **The editors have been notified.**

In this capacity, I have completed **review of 1 empirical research papers** and provide formal written evaluations assessing research design, analytic rigor, theoretical contribution, and relevance to the field.

(Exhibit B-12 Copy of completed ADVANCE Journal review (via Scholastica))

Judging 4 Conference Peer Reviewer- American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting

Evidence that I was invited to be a judge

I was selected to **serve as a peer reviewer for the 2026 American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting**, the flagship international conference in educational research. (Exhibit B-13: AERA reviewer invitation email).

Evidence that it is related to the field of higher education

I was selected to **serve as a peer reviewer for the 2026 American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting**, the flagship international conference in educational research. The American Educational Research Association (AERA) was founded in 1916 to professionalize educational research and improve education through scholarly inquiry, dissemination, and application of research. My responsibility as a reviewer was to support the collective growth and development of our colleagues in the field. Reviewers evaluate program proposals according to the Reviewer Rubric and provide comments with constructive feedback.

(Exhibit B-14: AERA organizational overview (“Who We Are”), B-15: AERA annual meeting review process documentation)

Evidence that I have completed the judging

Dear Martha Kakooza:

On behalf of the American Educational Research Association (AERA), we are writing to acknowledge your contribution to the AERA 2026 Annual Meeting by serving as a reviewer for submissions. The quality of the AERA Annual Meeting depends upon the substantive contributions of an extraordinarily dedicated group of researchers serving on peer review panels.

We are grateful for the work that you undertook this year. Serving on a peer review panel is a highly selective process. (Exhibit B-16: AERA Annual Meeting Reviewer Acknowledgement)

As proof of these claims, I have attached to this petition e-mails from the organizers of the AERA inviting my participation as a judge and thanking me after the judging process was completed (Exhibit B-17: AERA reviewer appointment confirmations and completed review records).

Judging 6 International Book Proposal Review- Bloomsbury

Evidence that I was invited to be a judge

I was formally invited by an editor at Bloomsbury Academic to serve as an external reviewer for a scholarly book proposal titled *Navigating Predominantly White Institutions: Coping Strategies and Resilience of Black Students* (Exhibit B-18: Bloomsbury Academic proposal review invitation email) for egalitarianism in higher education research. The invitation was extended based on recommendation by a senior scholar (Dr. Juana Hollingsworth), reflecting professional recognition of my subject-matter expertise in higher education research and higher education equity research.

Evidence that it is related to the field of higher education

The editor's description explicitly situates the book proposal within higher education research, examining institutional barriers, practices, and student resilience in UK Higher Education systems (Exhibit B-19: Bloomsbury Academic proposal submission form).

Evidence that I have completed the judging

Following acceptance of the invitation, I completed a formal written review of the proposal using Bloomsbury Academic's reviewer form and submitted my evaluative report by the requested deadline. As proof of these claims, I have attached to this petition e-mails Bloomsbury. (Exhibit B-20: Bloomsbury Academic proposal review questionnaire).

My repeated selection to judge the work of other scholars reflects professional trust in my ability to uphold standards of rigor, ethics, and methodological soundness in higher education research. By evaluating manuscripts and conference submissions, I helped shape the quality of research that defines doctoral training, scholarly norms, and professional practice. This work directly advances doctoral excellence and research integrity by reinforcing high standards for evidence, argumentation, and responsible knowledge production across the field. Across journals and national conferences, I have been **invited, selected, and relied upon** to judge the scholarly work of other researchers. **My completed reviews** demonstrate sustained professional trust in my expertise and satisfy the EB-1A criterion for participation as a judge of the work of others under **8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(iv)**.

3.3 Criterion 6 – Evidence of My Authorship of Scholarly Articles

As required by 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(vi), I provide evidence of my authorship of scholarly articles in the field, published in professional or major trade publications. This

criterion evaluates whether the petitioner has made original scholarly contributions through peer-reviewed publications that advance knowledge in the field in my case higher education research.

USCIS guidance specifies that this criterion requires evidence demonstrating:

1. My authorship in the field,
2. That the material is scholarly in nature, and
3. That the publications qualify as professional or major trade publications or other major media.

My publication record satisfies all three elements through peer-reviewed journal articles, an invited scholarly book chapter published by a major academic press, and editorial leadership in a peer-reviewed special issue within the field of higher education.

Authorship 1- Peer Reviewed Journal Article

Evidence of authorship within my field of study

I have authored and co-authored peer-reviewed journal articles that contribute original qualitative and theoretical scholarship to higher education research, with a particular focus on institutional culture in academic contexts and equity in higher education research.

I am a co-author of the peer-reviewed article:

Hollingsworth, J. D., & Kakooza, M. (2024). "Is my hair neat?! A duoethnography of Black women's cross-cultural socialization in academia." International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education (Exhibit C-1).

Evidence that the material is scholarly in nature

This article was an original duoethnographic study examining how Black women navigate **institutional norms, professionalism in doctoral education and training**. In addition this article was **explicitly cited in diasporic Black women's theorizing about the future of higher education**, curated by guest editors Dr. Meseret F. Hailu and Dr. Jeana Morrison (**Exhibit C-3: Call for Proposals citing Hollingsworth & Kakooza (2024), demonstrating scholarly recognition and influence on future research directions**).

This positioned my research **as part of the intellectual foundation guiding the scope, themes, and scholarly direction of the issue**. This article has also been cited in **dissertations in the United Kingdom and United States that is** Ball, E. L. S. A. (2024). *Negotiating liquid identity through hair supported by the salon experience* (Doctoral dissertation, Nottingham Trent University) and Bonds, M. Y. (2025). *The Art of Pretending: The Psychological Impact of Code-Switching On African American Women*

Leaders in Chicago Public Schools (Doctoral dissertation, National University) (**Exhibit C-4: Google Scholar citation record for “Is My Hair Neat?!”**).

Evidence that the publications qualify as professional or major trade publications or other major media.

The International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education is a peer-reviewed scholarly journal published by **Taylor & Francis, one of the world’s largest international academic publishers, producing over 2,700 peer-reviewed journals and an extensive global portfolio of scholarly books.** The journal is indexed in major academic databases (including Scopus, Web of Science, ERIC, and ProQuest) and reports an impact factor in the ~1.5 range (5-year ~1.9), reflecting sustained citation activity within education research. Accordingly, publication in this journal constitutes dissemination through a professional scholarly outlet of major significance. (Exhibit C-2: Journal indexing and impact information for International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education).

Authorship 2: First-Author Book Chapter Published by Emerald Publishing

Evidence of authorship within my field of study

I am the **first author** of an invited scholarly peer reviewed book chapter in the *Leadership in Turbulent Times* Book;

Kakooza, M., & Robinson, S. (2023). “The Table at Berkeley: An Ethnodrama Recounting the Experiences of Bisexual Faculty and Staff Navigating the Workplace.”
In *Leadership in Turbulent Times* (Emerald Publishing Limited) (**Exhibit C-6**).

Evidence that the material is scholarly in nature

Edited scholarly volumes published by Emerald undergo editorial review and contributor vetting and are intended for academic and professional audiences and was published in a textbook *Leadership in Turbulent Times* (Emerald Publishing Limited) (**Exhibit C-6: Kakooza & Robinson (2023), “The Table at Berkeley” – Chapter in *Leadership in Turbulent Times* (Emerald Publishing) (publisher proof and chapter excerpt), C-7: Emerald Publishing overview and editorial portfolio**)

Evidence that the publications qualify as professional or major trade publications or other major media.

Emerald Publishing Limited maintains a substantial international academic publishing portfolio, including over 300 peer-reviewed journals and thousands of scholarly books

across education, leadership, management, and organizational studies (**Exhibit C-7: Emerald Publishing overview and editorial portfolio**).

Emerald publications are curated through formal editorial processes involving academic editors and subject-matter experts, and contributors to edited volumes are typically invited or selected based on demonstrated scholarly expertise. Emerald titles are widely held by university libraries and research institutions worldwide (**Exhibit C-8: University library holdings demonstrating global distribution of the Emerald volume**), reinforcing Emerald's role as a trusted disseminator of peer-reviewed scholarship. Because Emerald specializes in academic publishing aligned directly with my chapter's focus on higher education, workplace experiences and academic leadership, publication by Emerald constitutes dissemination through a recognized professional scholarly publication.

Author 3: Co-Author for a Peer Reviewed Article

Evidence of authorship within my field of study

I have co-authored peer-reviewed journal articles that contribute original qualitative and theoretical scholarship to higher education research, with a particular focus on equity, institutional culture, and the experiences of Black women in academic settings.

I am a co-author of the peer-reviewed article:

Barlow, J. N., Kakooza, M., & Easley, M. (2023). "Writehealing: A Sistah's Circle Praxis to Heal and Liberate." *Women & Therapy* (**Exhibit C-9: Title Page of the Article**).

Evidence that the material is scholarly in nature

The article has been independently cited by other researchers in peer-reviewed scholarship and doctoral dissertations across institutions in the United States, demonstrating scholarly recognition of its contribution to the field (**Exhibit C 10: Google Scholar citation record for "Writehealing"**):

- Pelc, N., Dyer, R.L., & Whitmore, C. (2023). Conclusion to anti-racist feminist practice, advocacy, and activism special issue. *Women & Therapy*, Taylor & Francis. [Peer-reviewed journal article]
- Carlson, R. (2025). *The Tree That Would Not Fall: An Educator's Autoethnographic Journey of Healing Through Words*. [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]
- Coates, M.J. (2025). *What My Church Mother Taught Me: A Phenomenological Exploration of the Maternal Messages Given to Black Christian Women on How to Cope*. [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]
- Douglas, A.J. (2025). *The Strong Black Woman Schema: Help or Hindrance to Black Women's Mental Health?* [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]

- Raney, T.C. (2025). Evaluating the Impact of Mindfulness Traits, Emotional Regulation and Resilience on the Parental Stress of Black Mothers. [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]
- Tomlinson, S. (2024). Still, I Rise: A Framework for Transforming Experiences of Black Women Leaders in K-12 Urban Education. [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]
- Galmon, B. (2025). Perceptions of Systemic Racism and Perceived Well-Being in African American Mothers Raising African American Sons. [Doctoral dissertation, ProQuest]

Citation in doctoral dissertations, the highest level of academic training, confirms that this work is recognised by peer researchers as a credible scholarly resource within higher education equity research.

Evidence that the publication qualifies as a professional or major trade publication or other major media

Women & Therapy is a peer-reviewed scholarly journal published by Taylor & Francis (Routledge), one of the world's largest international academic publishers, producing over 2,700 peer-reviewed journals and an extensive global portfolio of scholarly books. The journal is indexed in major academic databases including Scopus, Web of Science, PsycINFO, and ProQuest, ensuring broad reach across the research community in psychology, public health, and education. Accordingly, publication in this journal constitutes dissemination through a professional scholarly outlet of major significance (**Exhibit C11 Journal indexing and impact information for Women & Therapy**).

Author 4: Co-Author Book Chapter by Cambridge University Press

Evidence of authorship within my field of study

I am a co-author of the peer-reviewed book chapter titled "*How Institutional Policies and Practices Impact Black Immigrant College Students' Experiences*," published by Cambridge University Press in an edited scholarly volume focused on higher education (**Exhibit C-9: Chapter in *Supporting College Students of Immigrant Origin* (Cambridge University Press) – chapter title page and book cover**).

This chapter appears in:

Silver, B. R., & McCarron, G. P. (2024). *Supporting College Students of Immigrant Origin: New Insights from Research, Policy, and Practice*.

Evidence that the material is scholarly in nature

The chapter was published in a peer-reviewed edited academic volume intended for researchers, practitioners, and policymakers in higher education. Edited volumes published by Cambridge University Press undergo formal editorial vetting and scholarly review prior to acceptance. The book *Supporting College Students of Immigrant Origin*:

New Insights from Research, Policy, and Practice is held in **195 university libraries worldwide**, as documented through WorldCat (***Exhibit C-10: WorldCat library holdings for *Supporting College Students of Immigrant Origin****). Widespread acquisition by research universities demonstrates that this volume is used as an academic resource rather than commercial or popular media.

Evidence that the publications qualify as professional or major trade publications or other major media.

Cambridge University Press (CUP) is one of the world's oldest and most prestigious academic publishers. Founded in **1534**, CUP is the official publishing arm of the University of Cambridge and is widely regarded as a benchmark publisher of scholarly and professional research (***Exhibit C-11: Cambridge University Press publisher overview***).

Cambridge University Press operates at global scale, distributing publications in **more than 200 countries**, with most sales occurring outside the United Kingdom, demonstrating international scholarly reach.

CUP publishes an extensive portfolio of professional academic content, including:

- **Over 420 peer-reviewed journals** across education, social sciences, sciences, and humanities
- **Cambridge Core**, its digital platform, hosting approximately **1.6 million journal articles and 46,000 academic ebooks**
- Independent publisher directories reporting **53,000+ academic titles** and **350+ research journals** spanning education, leadership, and organizational studies.

Because Cambridge University Press specializes exclusively in academic publishing and disseminates peer-reviewed scholarship to global research audiences, publication of my chapter constitutes dissemination through a **major professional scholarly outlet**.

3.4 Criterion 7: Evidence of the display of work

Evidence that USCIS Policy Manual/Regulations allow for comparable evidence of a criterion when it does not readily apply to the petitioner's occupation

As required by 8 CFR § 204.5(h)(3)(vii), "display of the person's work in the field at artistic exhibitions or showcases," I provide comparable evidence demonstrating the public display of my scientific work at professional venues. Although this criterion is primarily intended for artistic professions, ***USCIS allows for the submission of comparable evidence when a criterion does not readily apply to the petitioner's occupation, as specified in 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(4)***. In education, traditional artistic exhibitions are generally not a medium through which professional recognition is achieved.

Evidence that the criterion does not apply to my occupation

The intent behind USCIS Criterion 7 is to demonstrate that an individual's work has been deemed worthy of public exhibition and professional scrutiny as required by 8 CFR § 204.5(h)(3)(vii). In education research, this function is fulfilled through curated conference presentations, invited talks, and competitive poster sessions where original research is displayed, evaluated, and discussed by expert audiences. *MerriamWebster's definition of "exhibition" includes "a public showing of works of art, objects of manufacture, or athletic skill)," which parallels the professional presentation of educational research.*

In the field of education, original scholarship **is publicly exhibited through posters and presentation disseminated primarily through peer-reviewed annual conferences hosted by major professional associations** such as the American Educational Research Association (AERA) and the Association for the Study of Higher Education (ASHE), **where proposals are competitively evaluated by expert reviewers and presented to qualified scholarly audiences.**

These conferences serve as the formal mechanism for public presentation of peer-vetted research and are the academic equivalent of professional exhibitions (**Exhibit D-1: AERA Proposal Review and Selection Process, D-2: ASHE Competitive Conference Review Process**)

Evidence that the equivalent of an artist's display of work for your field is presentation of your work at conferences, etc

In educational research, original scholarship is not exhibited through galleries but through competitively selected conference presentations and poster sessions. Major professional associations such as the American Educational Research Association and the Association for the Study of Higher Education publicly disseminate peer-reviewed research through formal conference programs, poster sessions, and paper presentations curated by expert review committees. These venues function as the disciplinary equivalent of artistic exhibitions by providing selective, juried platforms for public display and professional scrutiny of original work. **American Educational Research Association (AERA)** and the **Association for the Study of Higher Education(ASHE)** are among the most prominent professional organizations in education and higher education research.

AERA is an international scholarly association serving tens of thousands of education researchers worldwide and hosts one of the largest annual education research conferences globally, featuring thousands of peer-reviewed sessions selected through a multi-stage review process conducted by senior scholars and methodological experts, with acceptance based on originality, rigor, and contribution to the field (**Exhibit D-3: AERA organizational overview and annual meeting review framework, D-7: Documentation of AERA national scholarly audience**)

ASHE is the leading professional organization devoted exclusively to higher education research in the United States, and its annual conference is widely regarded as the premier

national venue for higher education scholarship, attracting faculty researchers, doctoral students, and policy leaders from across institutions; ASHE proposals similarly undergo competitive peer review (**Exhibit D-5: ASHE conference poster and paper session descriptions, D-6: Documentation of ASHE national scholarly audience**)

Accordingly, presentation of peer-reviewed research at national conferences such as ASHE and AERA among others represents the academic equivalent of an artist's exhibition. USCIS expressly permits reliance on such comparable evidence when a regulatory criterion does not directly apply to the petitioner's occupation, pursuant to 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(4).

Evidence of presentation of my work at conferences

2024 – ASHE Annual Conference, Minneapolis, MN

My peer-reviewed paper, "*Gender Equality and Institutional Support in Ugandan Higher Education: Experiences of Women in Engineering*," was accepted for a competitive paper session at ASHE's annual conference, one of the premier venues for higher education research. Acceptance reflects peer recognition of the relevance and quality of my work in comparative and international higher education.

(Exhibit D-12: 2024 "Congratulations / Proposal Accepted" email notifications from conference organizers)

2022 – ASHE Annual Conference, Las Vegas, NV

I presented two peer-reviewed papers:

- "*Cross Stitching Our Stories: Unweaving the Threads of Narrative Self-Construction in Black Women and Femmes' Personal Statements in STEM*"
- "*The Othering of Blackness in the Academy: A Duoethnography of Black Women's Cross-Cultural Experiences*"

(Exhibit D-13: 2022 "Congratulations / Proposal Accepted" email notifications from conference organizers)

These presentations demonstrate continued scholarly engagement with higher education research audiences and show consistency in my research agenda over time.

2025- African Studies Program- University of Toronto Scarborough

"Ubuntu as a Framework for Restoring Autonomy in Research on Black Women's Higher Education Experiences."

(Exhibit D-9: Letter of invitation submitted for Canadian visa application (confirming international participation,))

2023 – AERA Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL

I co-presented the peer-reviewed paper "*The Role of Culture, Gender, and Race in Black Immigrant Girls' Math Identity Development*." AERA is the **largest international education research conference**, and acceptance through its competitive review process demonstrates that my work met the field's highest scholarly standards

(Exhibit D-10 Presentation slides cover page for AERA).

2023- American College Professionals Association (ACPA) Meeting, New Orleans, LA

I co presented Ubuntu when we become well for wellness among doctoral students.

Additional Education-Related Scholarly Presentations (Continuity of Record)

- **2022 – International Conference on Urban Education (ICUE), Cancun, Mexico**
Peer-reviewed paper on mathematics identity and intersectionality in education.
- **2022 – Johns Hopkins University Diversity & Inclusion Conference**
Invited session on transnational experiences of Black women in U.S. higher education.
- **2022 – Africana Studies Interdisciplinary Conference, James Madison University**
Peer-reviewed paper on narrative identity in educational contexts.

The repeated selection of my work by expert committees over multiple years demonstrates sustained recognition and satisfies the intent of 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(3)(vii) through comparable evidence appropriate to my field.

4. Kazarian Final Merits Determination

Following what is established in the Kazarian opinion, the second step of the two-part approach is a final merits determination that considers **all of the evidence** in the context of whether or not the petitioner has demonstrated:

- A level of expertise indicating that she is “one of that small percentage who have risen to the very top of the field of endeavor.” 8 C.F.R. §204.5(h)(2); and
- Sustained national or international acclaim and that her achievements have been recognized in the field of her expertise. 8 C.F.R. §204.5(h)(3).

I have not only demonstrated that I meet at least four of the regulatory criteria, but my evidence overall demonstrates my national and international acclaim. The evidence provided (as outlined in this letter) proves that I have extraordinary abilities in the field of education.

- Nationally and internationally recognized honors and awards, conferred through competitive, peer-reviewed selection processes that reflect recognition of merit and professional impact.
- Participation as a judge of the work of others, through service as a peer reviewer, review board member, conferences, and scholarly initiatives for academic journals
- Authorship of scholarly articles in the field, including peer-reviewed journal articles, an invited book chapter, and peer-reviewed conference proceedings that contribute original knowledge to research on doctoral education, graduate student development, and institutional practice;
- Comparable evidence of the display of my work at professional venues, demonstrated through competitively selected conference presentations, invited lectures, national webinar series, and international scholarly forums where my work has been presented to expert audiences;

4.1 Totality of the Evidence and Standing in the Field

My record reflects a sustained pattern of professional recognition based on **original scholarly contributions**, selective dissemination of my work, and service in evaluative and leadership capacities for respected academic and professional organizations. My research addresses central questions in higher education concerning doctoral training, graduate admissions, mentoring, and institutional climate, with a particular focus on how institutional structures and evaluative practices shape academic outcomes.

The impact and significance of my scholarly work have been recognized by independent scholars, academic units, and institutions within the field of higher education through conference proceedings. **My research on doctoral education and STEM graduate education has extended beyond peer-reviewed publications and conference proceedings to inform invited lectures, workshops, and expert presentations at**

nationally and internationally recognized institutions. For the adjudicator's convenience, I have included my complete curriculum vitae, which provides a consolidated record of my education, research training, awards, leadership activities, and professional service.

I further demonstrate national and local recognition of my research through the acceptance of my work for presentation at the Baltimore Immigration Summit, an initiative by the Baltimore City Government. In February 2026, my research was competitively selected for poster presentation at this summit, which brings together policymakers, researchers, and community stakeholders to address equity in higher education research. The Summit is set to take place on May 30, 2026

(Exhibit FM-1 12th Annual Baltimore Immigration Summit | Baltimore City)

The selection of my work for this venue reflects recognition of its relevance to pressing social and policy concerns in higher education research, specifically STEM graduate research. The Summit serves as a platform for sharing research that can inform public understanding, community engagement, and policy discussions. My participation as a presenter demonstrates that my work is not only academically grounded but also contributes to broader conversations.

This recognition further supports my record of contributing to the dissemination of knowledge in spaces that bridge research, policy, and practice, reinforcing the impact and relevance of my scholarly work.

(Exhibit FM-2: Email invitation from the Baltimore Immigration Summit).

Good afternoon,

We are pleased to inform you that your poster proposal has been accepted for presentation at the Baltimore Immigration Summit (BIS).

To confirm your participation, please complete the Baltimore Immigration Summit – Presenter Submission Form by March 31. This form serves as your official registration. Submission confirms your agreement to attend and present your poster at the Summit.

We look forward to showcasing your work and appreciate your contribution to this year's Summit. Additional logistical information will be shared following confirmation. Please contact us with any questions.

Sincerely,

Baltimore Immigration Summit Planning Committee

Sustaining my acclaim, in 2022, I was invited to be a Panelist for the NASPA Faculty Council Doctoral Seminar

Hi Martha,

I hope you are well. Clifton recommended you as a potential panelist for the NASPA Faculty Council's Doctoral Seminar at this year's annual conference. The seminar will be held in person in Baltimore on Sunday, March 20, 2022 from 12:00-4:00 pm ET.

The doctoral seminar was created to provide support and information for higher education and student affairs doctoral students to help them successfully navigate the process. Faculty, administrators, and doctoral students will facilitate conversations and structured time to discuss success strategies and identity influences in the doctoral experience as well as career pathways post-degree. I'm attaching the flyer to offer more information

(Exhibit FM-3: Official Email invitation from the NASPA Faculty Council Coordinator confirming the Petitioner's selection as a panelist for the Doctoral Seminar (invitation based on peer recommendation)).

Panelists were recommended by senior members in the organization to lead discussions and provide guidance to a national audience of doctoral students. As a panelist, I was the only student on the panel among faculty members and shared my advice on navigating doctoral study and launching an academic career

(Exhibit FM-3: Photograph of seminar panelists displaying the Petitioner's name and image, documenting her role as the only doctoral student invited to serve alongside faculty panelists).

I answered questions, guided discussion, and provided mentorship to participants across institutions nationwide. In this role, I functioned as an advisor and role model for emerging scholars in higher education. **My selection as a panelist reflects national organizational recognition of my expertise in doctoral student development.** By guiding discussion, responding to participant questions, and shaping how attendees thought about their doctoral training and graduate education. The Faculty Council Doctoral Seminar is offered as part of the Annual Conference, an event that regularly attracts 5,000–7,000 Vice Presidents, Provosts among other administrators, and scholars from across the United States and abroad

Additionally through the years, I have been invited to share at these avenues

- *Thriving in Graduate School as a Business Leader: A Holistic Approach to Occupational Wellbeing and Leadership*— Johns Hopkins Carey Business School (August 2024) **(Exhibit FM 4 Leadership Development Program Carey Business School THREE-DAY IMMERSION 2024-2025)**
- Cross-Stitching Our Stories: Unweaving the Threads of Narrative Self-Construction in Black Women and Femmes' Personal Statements Virtual

lecture for *The Psychology of the African American Experience* course, North Carolina State University, Raleigh, NC (October 2021)

These invitations were extended based on my scholarly expertise and published work and reflect professional recognition of the relevance and applicability of my research to faculty, administrators, graduate students, and institutional leaders. Collectively, they demonstrate that I am fully qualified as a person of extraordinary ability in the field of STEM Education, Doctoral Pathways and egalitarianism in higher education research.

Expert letters tying my work to the U.S. STEM capacity

Furthermore Dr. Earl Lee, **Assistant Dean of Inclusive Excellence and Clinical Assistant Professor at the John Shufeldt School of Medicine and Medical Engineering at Arizona State University**, shared an expert opinion letter on my work sharing;

I have been familiar with Ms. Kakooza's work since 2021 and I have found that it addresses matters of substantial national importance by strengthening the U.S. STEM education and research pipeline through original, evidence-based research focused on mentorship, graduate training, and institutional accountability. *Her contributions constitute authorship, judging and speaking engagements, as they expand access to high-impact STEM pathways while directly enhancing national research capacity and workforce readiness. By cultivating durable partnerships between higher education and industry and equipping students with critical competencies, her efforts materially increase the nation's innovation potential in emerging fields such as artificial intelligence, biotechnology, cybersecurity, and sustainable energy. Ms. Kakooza's contributions provide clear prospective benefit to the United States by advancing a resilient, globally competitive, and inclusive STEM workforce*

(Exhibit FM 4: Reference letter from Dr. Earl Lee + CV)

The expert opinion of Dr. Earl Lee, a renowned figure in the field of STEM educational research, based on years of observing my work without personal or professional acquaintance underscores the sustained level of my acclaim and wide-reaching impact of my contributions to the field. This independent validation from a respected expert in the field demonstrates my fulfillment of the EB-1A criteria of sustained national or international acclaim and being among the top in my professional sphere.

4.2 Sustained National and International Recognition

My professional recognition reflects **sustained and geographically broad acclaim**. Over the past couple of years, my work has been recognized by the **U.S.-based and international universities** engaged in higher education research, STEM graduate education, doctoral training and equity in higher education research. My scholarship has been **publicly disseminated through invited presentations, incorporated into national and international scholarly programming, and referenced in ongoing field-wide**

discussions concerning doctoral education, mentoring systems, and institutional accountability.

International and National Higher Education Organizations appointments

On February 12th 2026, I was appointed to be a part of the board of committee for the Association of the Study of Higher Education, the premier higher education organization in the United States (**Exhibit FM 5 Email from Dr. Guilbeau, Exhibit FM 6 ASHE conference details**) .

February 12, 2026

To: Martha Kakooza

From: Jason P. Guilbeau, PhD, CAE, ASHE Executive Director

Subject: Appointment to ASHE Council for Ethnic Participation (CEP)

Dear Martha,

On behalf of the Association for the Study of Higher Education (ASHE), I am pleased to share that Council for Ethnic Participation (CEP) Chair Antonio Duran has appointed you as a member of the group's Pre-Con Committee to serve for the term of 2/6/2026- 11/6/2026.

Thank you for your willingness to shape the future of our scholarly community through this role. Your commitment ensures ASHE remains a supportive network where diverse ideas and scholars flourish.

A central indicator of my national standing and sustained acclaim is my appointment to a leadership role within the Association for the Study of Higher Education (ASHE), the premier professional organization for higher education research. I was selected by national leadership to serve on the Council for Ethnic Participation (CEP) Pre-Conference Committee, an appointment that is both selective and given to only top individuals in the field. As the email states, this role directly shapes scholarly discourse by influencing conference programming, thematic direction, and the professional development of emerging scholars in higher education research. Involvement at this level demonstrates that established leaders in the field recognize my work as a scholar in guiding national conversations on STEM graduate research, equity in higher education research and doctoral pathways. This appointment is consistent with and reinforces my broader record of scholarly and professional contributions.

My national recognition is further evidenced by my selection to serve on the Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Committee Leadership Team of the POD Network (Professional and Organizational Development Network in Higher Education). I was competitively selected as a Fellowship and Grants Coordinator for a two-year term, a leadership-level role that involves oversight of funding mechanisms that support scholars and practitioners across institutions.

Dear Martha,

Congratulations! You have been selected to serve on the POD Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Committee Leadership Team as a Fellowship & Grants coordinator. We were impressed with your response provided in your application, and look forward to working with you. This position is a two-year term from January 2026 - December 2027.

Best regards,
Anoff Cobblah

This position is particularly significant because **fellowship and grant coordination directly influences which projects, scholars, and initiatives receive institutional support and visibility in STEM graduate education, doctoral pathways and equity in higher education research.** In this capacity, I contribute to shaping the pipeline of scholarship and professional development within higher education, especially in areas related to **egalitarianism**. Such responsibilities are reserved for individuals whose expertise and judgment **are trusted to guide resource allocation and support emerging leaders in the field.**

POD Network invests about \$10K–\$25K total towards Wulff Fellows, and for other projects within this network \$30K–\$100K+ annually depending on awards, up to \$5,500 per project. Up to \$12,000 for cross-institutional projects for this program which I will help lead.

(Exhibit FM 7 The 2019 Collaborative Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Educational Development Fellows Program).

I further demonstrate my sustained acclaim in the field of higher education when I was chosen as Associate Editor for the American Journal of Education Forum (Exhibit FM 8 Email Welcome to the American Journal of Education), where I served from 2021 to 2024 on the Student Advisory Board. The Forum is a companion platform to the American Journal of Education (Exhibit FM 9 American Journal of Education Publisher's Report from UCP February 2021) that highlights emerging and ongoing issues in education, extending the reach of scholarly conversations to a broader academic audience. The American Journal of Education is a well-established, peer-reviewed academic journal founded in 1893 and published by the University of Chicago Press. It is indexed in major

databases such as Web of Science and Scopus, which are used to track the impact and reach of scholarly work.

The journal has a long publication history of over 130 years and uses a competitive peer-review process to evaluate submissions. Articles published in the journal are widely cited by researchers and policymakers, reflecting its role in shaping research and practice in education.

In my role as Associate Editor, ***I was responsible for overseeing the development and editorial review of submissions within the reviews section.*** This included evaluating the quality, relevance, and scholarly contribution of submitted pieces, as well as guiding content that engages critical issues in education (**Exhibit FM 10 AJE Reviewer Policy and Documents**). Through this work, ***I contributed to determining which ideas and perspectives were elevated within the Forum, thereby shaping discourse around higher educational issues.***

The Forum plays an important role in complementing the journal's formal publication process by fostering timely scholarly engagement and increasing accessibility to key conversations in the field. ***My editorial responsibilities required the application of scholarly judgment and reflect trust in my ability to assess and advance higher education research both nationally and internationally.*** (**Exhibit FM 9 American Journal of Education Publisher's Report from UCP February 2021**)

This experience demonstrates that my expertise in higher education research is recognized not only in leadership and programmatic contexts, but also in the **evaluation, curation, and dissemination of scholarly knowledge**, reinforcing my broader impact on the field of higher education.

National policy convenings

In 2024, I was specially invited to participate in a high-level, invitation-only workshop jointly convened by the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM) and the Association of American Universities (AAU) titled ***Taking Doctoral Mentorship Seriously: Institutional Design for Equity and Inclusive Excellence.***

The purpose of the workshop was to address a matter of national importance: the structure, effectiveness, and equity of doctoral mentorship in U.S. higher education, with the goal of informing future institutional and policy guidance

(Exhibit FM-10: Invitation email to participate in Taking Doctoral Mentorship Seriously: Institutional Design for Equity and Inclusive Excellence).

The National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM) is the United States' most authoritative independent advisory body on science, engineering, medicine, and education policy, chartered by Congress in

1863 and relied upon by federal agencies to produce consensus reports that shape national research priorities and institutional practice. The Association of American Universities (AAU) is an elite, invitation-only consortium of 71 leading research universities responsible for approximately \$38.23 billion in federally funded basic research (about 64% of the U.S. total), serving as primary drivers of doctoral education, scientific innovation, and national competitiveness

(Exhibit FM-11: Organizational profiles for the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine and the Association of American Universities).

As stated by **Mr. Dominique Turner, Senior Associate Dean in the Office of Student and Community Development at Alleghany College and one of the participants** in the conveying states in his reference letter (**Exhibit 12: Reference letter from Mr. Dominique Turner + CV**)

Ms. Kakooza's presence added value to the convening in two specific ways. First, she brought a strong analytical lens to discussions of doctoral mentorship, connecting individual mentoring practices to broader institutional policies and structures. Second, she contributed to solution-oriented dialogue by helping translate themes from the convening into actionable considerations for improving doctoral mentorship and inclusive educational excellence. Her contributions were consistent with the expectations placed on participants in a convening of this nature, where the quality of discussion and the development of recommendations depend on participants' expertise and judgment. **Martha is an accomplished scholar, a dedicated mentor in her own right, and was a key collaborator at the convening.**

This record demonstrates that my work has been **repeatedly sought out by external institutions and professional organizations**, independent of my home institution or immediate collaborators. Consistent with precedent, sustained acclaim is established where a petitioner's contributions continue to attract attention across time and contexts. The evidentiary record confirms that my scholarship meets this standard through **ongoing engagement, dissemination, and application** at the national and international levels.

4.3 Significance of Contributions

My scholarly contributions address issues of substantial importance to U.S. higher education, including the effectiveness of doctoral training, STEM graduate education, and the role of institutional design in shaping educational outcomes. **Through peer-reviewed publications and invited national presentations, my research informs evidence-based reform efforts that strengthen the academic research pipeline and advance institutional accountability.**

The national significance of this work is demonstrated through my continued collaborations and recognized roles with the Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN), the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine, the Association of American Universities, the Professional and Organizational Development

Network in Higher Education, and the Association of American Colleges and Universities (AAC&U), where my expertise contributes to shaping dialogue, guidance, and practice related to STEM graduate education and doctoral training

Translational national webinars

In 2023, following the release of the National Academies' consensus report *Advancing Antiracism, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion in STEMM Organizations*, I was invited by IGEN to serve as one of four expert respondents for a national webinar jointly hosted by IGEN and the National Academies titled *Beyond Broadening Participation: Graduate Education and STEMM Organizations*. The webinar reached more than 200 participants nationwide and was designed to translate national-level guidance into actionable strategies for STEM graduate education (**Exhibit FM-14: Webinar flyer – Beyond Broadening Participation: Graduate Education and STEMM Organizations**). I was asked to be a part of generating a new report to contextualize its findings for graduate education, highlight implications for broadening participation, and facilitate breakout discussions focused on operationalizing national recommendations within institutional settings (**Exhibit FM-15: Follow-up report *Advancing Antiracism, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion in STEMM Organizations*, showing petitioners contribution**).

These invited expert engagements, sustained collaborations, and applied translational activities demonstrate that my work is not only scholarly, but also materially informs national conversations and institutional practices related to doctoral training, STEM workforce development, and educational equity, establishing the broader significance of my original contributions.

4.4 Continued Contributions and Future Impact:

My education, training, and scholarly record position me to continue contributing to U.S. national interests in doctoral education and Science, Technology, Engineering Mathematics graduate training, particularly in areas emphasized by federal research agencies such as the National Science Foundation (NSF) and the National Institutes of Health (NIH). Both agencies identify effective doctoral mentoring, rigorous research training, and institutional accountability as essential to sustaining the nation's research workforce and maximizing public investment in graduate education.

My work examines how doctoral program design, mentoring practices, and evaluative norms shape student development and research engagement, producing evidence that informs program improvement and training reform. In addition to research contributions, my invited scholarly engagement, professional service, and mentorship activities support the preparation of future researchers and educators and reinforce standards of rigor and integrity in doctoral education. Through continued research, publication, and service in the United States, I will remain positioned to contribute to strengthening doctoral training

environments in ways that align with federally articulated priorities for research capacity, workforce development, and institutional effectiveness.

4.5 Conclusion Under the Kazarian Framework

Considering the totality of the evidence, my record demonstrates sustained recognition, independent validation of my work, and a level of achievement that distinguishes me from the majority of scholars in the field of education. The evidence supports a finding that I have attained **a level of expertise and professional standing consistent with individuals who have risen to the small percentage at the top of the field**, as contemplated by 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(2).

Accordingly, I meet the final merits determination under the *Kazarian* framework and qualify for classification as an individual of extraordinary ability under 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h)(1).

5. Continuing to Work in the Area of Expertise

I am exceptionally well positioned to continue my work in the field of **education**, with specialized expertise in **STEM graduate education, doctoral student development, and doctoral pathways**. My advanced training in educational research equips me to generate and apply evidence-based approaches that improve doctoral training, mentoring systems, and graduate education outcomes. I have contributed to **federally supported initiatives**, including work connected to the **Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN)**, that advance pathways into STEM graduate education and inform national reform efforts.

5.1 Entry Showing Substantial Benefit to the United States

STEM graduate education is a **strategic national priority** because **doctoral training underpins the United States' research, innovation, and technological leadership**. As the U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) request for information stated

“Educational institutions partners would form highly collaborative research teams to meet the aggressive goals of the Genesis Mission. They would also establish new curricula and experiences for training bachelor’s and master’s level students, in AI for Science and Engineering and the future AI workforce, as well as research experiences as part of doctoral and post-doctoral associate training.”

Strengthening doctoral training environments in partnership with higher education professional organizations is therefore essential to maintaining U.S. competitiveness in science and engineering. My current doctoral training in Higher Education at **Morgan State University**, a preeminent urban research institution, provides advanced theoretical and applied expertise in **doctoral socialization, mentoring, and STEM graduate education systems**. This foundation enables me to make sustained contributions to improving graduate education structures, mentoring practices, and accountability mechanisms that influence doctoral persistence, research productivity, and professional development across diverse institutional contexts. These contributions directly support the expansion of U.S. scientific and engineering capacity.

My professional trajectory demonstrates a **clear and consistent continuation within STEM graduate education**. I intend to remain in academia and sustain partnerships with nationally recognized organizations such as the **Professional and Organizational Development (POD) Network**, the **National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM)**, the **Association of American Universities (AAU)**, and the **Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN)**. As the United States Department of Energy (DOE) cites in their issue

- *Philanthropic organizations interested in supporting AI for Science and Engineering research and student training.*
- *Think tanks and other research organizations.*

are important in order to achieve national and global importance in Science and Engineering(*Exhibit 7 Mobilizing Talent for the Genesis Mission and Developing an American Workforce to Advance Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Science and Engineering*).

Through these partnerships with these organizations, I will continue advancing research on doctoral mentoring and academic integration in STEM fields, developing evidence-based frameworks for institutional accountability, contributing to national conversations on doctoral program design and climate, and collaborating with faculty and administrators to translate research into practice.

As required by **8 CFR § 204.5(h)(5)**, my entry and continued work in the United States will provide a **substantial prospective benefit**. By strengthening STEM graduate education systems, improving doctoral mentoring quality, and advancing institutional accountability, my work supports the development of a highly trained scientific workforce essential to national research capacity, innovation, and economic competitiveness. These contributions align with federal priorities in graduate education reform and ensure that public investment in doctoral training yields sustained national returns.

5.2 Ongoing and Future Contributions

Doctoral education functions as a foundational component of the U.S. research and innovation ecosystem. Weaknesses in mentoring structures, program design, and institutional climate undermine research productivity, delay entry into the scientific workforce, and diminish returns on federal investment in graduate education. Addressing these structural challenges is therefore a matter of national importance.

My research directly responds to these concerns by examining how **institutional practices and evaluative norms shape doctoral access, persistence, and training quality**, and by offering analytically grounded frameworks for reform.

This work contributes to national conversations on doctoral admissions, equity, and accountability by identifying how institutional expectations shape access to advanced training and by offering implications for more responsible and inclusive evaluative practices.

My work aligns closely with these federal priorities by focusing on **institutional design, mentoring systems, and evidence-based reform in STEM graduate education**. Through collaboration with universities, professional organizations, and federally supported networks, I contribute to initiatives that strengthen academic preparation, improve doctoral training environments, and better align educational pathways with workforce and research needs.

To maximize national impact, I will continue collaborating with educational institutions, philanthropic institutions, and think tanks to support sustainable improvements in Science,

Technology, Engineering and Mathematics graduate education. My professional network and leadership roles include membership and service with the **Inclusive Graduate Education Network on their Research Advisory Board**, selection as an AAC&U **Future Leaders Society** participant, and my current appointment as a **Donald H. Wulff Fellow with the Professional and Organizational Development (POD) Network** positions me to establish and sustain partnerships that advance federal goals for graduate education reform.

In this national leadership role, I will manage Donald H. Wulff DEI Travel Fellowship and Mentorship Program and the DEI Mini-Grant Program competitive initiatives that support education scholars and catalyze institutional change across doctoral-granting institutions. **Working closely with conference leadership, I will ensure visibility of fellowship recipients' scholarship** through dedicated roundtable sessions at POD's annual conference and facilitate pathways for past awardees to contribute to national discourse on educational development. My biannual assessment reports will provide evidence-based insights that inform program evolution and demonstrate measurable outcomes in diversifying the field of education, work that directly complements my research on institutional accountability and inclusive evaluative practices. **This appointment strengthens my capacity to advance federal priorities by positioning me within the premier professional network for educational developers, enabling me to scale evidence-based mentorship models, shape national conversations on equity in graduate education, and translate research findings into actionable reform across American higher education institutions.**

In summary, my academic training, nationally recognized service, and program development experience position me to make **ongoing, scalable contributions** to strengthening doctoral education and STEM graduate training in the United States, supporting long-term national research capacity and institutional accountability.

5.3 Substantial Prospective Benefit to the United States

My continued presence in the United States will yield substantial national benefit through:

- Advancing evidence-based approaches to doctoral education and STEM workforce development
- Strengthening institutional accountability and mentoring structures in higher education
- Supporting federal priorities related to research capacity, graduate completion, and educational quality
- Contributing to the training and development of future researchers, educators, and public-service leaders

My work and initiatives exemplify broadening the talent pool to engage United States citizens through graduate education and doctoral training. This is critical because STEM occupations drive a disproportionate share of growth, despite comprising only about 5% of U.S. jobs, the STEM workforce generates over 50% of sustained economic growth. In

short, my efforts directly address the urgent national need to **expand the STEM graduate education and doctoral training**, thereby fueling innovation and economic competitiveness.

My expertise, sustained scholarly activity, and leadership in education research related to STEM education, doctoral education and equity focused education, demonstrate that my continued work will provide national-level benefits and places me at the top of my field in higher education specifically STEM graduate education and higher education research, fully satisfying the EB-1A requirement.

6. Conclusion

Based on the evidence submitted, I respectfully submit that I qualify as an individual of extraordinary ability in education under Section 203(b)(1)(A) of the Immigration and Nationality Act and 8 C.F.R. § 204.5(h). My record demonstrates sustained national and international recognition in the field of education, with a particular emphasis on doctoral education, STEM graduate training, and equity focused research, as evidenced through peer-reviewed scholarship, invited scholarly engagement, critical roles, among others.

These achievements demonstrate more than isolated success. They reflect a consistent pattern of professional recognition, reliance on my expertise by established organizations, and repeated selection for roles involving evaluation, and dissemination of knowledge. The breadth of venues, institutions, and audiences involved shows that my work has been recognized beyond a single employer or academic setting.

My continued presence in the United States will substantially benefit the nation by advancing research and practice related to higher education, Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics graduate education, doctoral education and higher education equity research. My work aligns with federal priorities that emphasize improving STEM graduate education quality, strengthening research capacity, and ensuring effective use of public investment in higher education. Through continued research, publication, mentorship, and professional service, I will continue contributing to the preparation of future scholars and to evidence-based improvement of U.S. higher-education systems.

Accordingly, the totality of the evidence establishes that I meet the statutory and regulatory requirements for classification as an individual of extraordinary ability under the EB-1A category. I respectfully request favorable adjudication of this petition.

7. Signed Statement of Intent to Continue Work in the United States

March 2nd 2026

My name is Martha Kakooza, and I am the beneficiary of this Form I-140 Immigrant Petition for Alien Worker, seeking classification as an individual of extraordinary ability (EB-1A). I am an higher educational researcher whose work focuses on STEM graduate and doctoral education, with particular emphasis on broadening participation, strengthening doctoral mentoring systems, and advancing inclusive excellence in U.S. higher education.

I have been invited to contribute my expertise through selective, national-level roles with distinguished organizations that shape U.S. science and education policy. These include participation in invitation-only convenings and initiatives led by the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM), the Association of American Universities (AAU), and the Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN). Through these engagements, I have supported national conversations on doctoral mentorship, and equity in STEM graduate education, contributing analytical and practice-oriented perspectives that inform policy and institutional guidance.

As a permanent resident, I intend to remain in academia and sustain partnerships with nationally recognized organizations such as the Professional and Organizational Development (POD) Network, the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (NASEM), the Association of American Universities (AAU), and the Inclusive Graduate Education Network (IGEN). Permanent residency will enable me to expand this work through sustained research collaboration, and international collaborations and funding supporting innovations in doctoral training and STEM graduate education. By strengthening the systems that educate and mentor students, my work contributes materially to national priorities in STEM education and technological innovation by ensuring a robust, diverse, and well-trained STEM workforce.

In return for the opportunities afforded by permanent residency, I will continue to dedicate my career to advancing STEM graduate education, higher education scholars maintaining research universities and opportunities and mentoring future educational scientists and scholars, and contributing to the scientific capacity and economic competitiveness of the United States. I respectfully request favorable consideration of this petition and appreciate the opportunity to continue serving the nation through my research, mentorship, and national engagement.

Respectfully,

Martha Kakooza,

29 Linden Terrace, Towson, MD, 21286

makak1@morgan.edu, 445-519-6759